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NCE Predicted Examination Paper — 2026

2026

ENGLISH

GRADE 9 • PAPER 1 OF 4

Time Allowed: **2 hours 15 minutes**

Total Marks: **100**

Candidate Name: _____

School: _____

INSTRUCTIONS TO CANDIDATES

1. Read all instructions carefully before you begin.
2. Answer **ALL** questions in Sections A, B and D.
3. In Section C (Writing), answer **ONE** task only.
4. Write your answers in the spaces provided.
5. The marks available for each question are shown in a box [].
6. Use blue or black ink. Pencil may be used for diagrams only.
7. Dictionaries are **not** permitted.

Section	Topic	Available	Obtained
A	Reading Comprehension	30	
B	Language Use	25	
C	Writing	30	
D	Vocabulary & Word Study	15	
TOTAL		100	

SECTION A — READING COMPREHENSION [30 marks]

Read the passage carefully, then answer **ALL** the questions that follow.

The Digital Generation: How Social Media Is Reshaping Young Lives

The rise of social media has transformed the way teenagers communicate, learn, and perceive themselves. Platforms such as Instagram, TikTok, and Snapchat have become integral parts of adolescent life, with the average teenager spending over three hours daily scrolling through feeds, posting updates, and engaging with content. While these platforms offer remarkable opportunities for connection and creativity, researchers and parents alike are raising serious concerns about their long-term effects on young people's mental health and social development.

One of the most frequently cited benefits of social media is the ability to maintain friendships across distances. For teenagers who have moved to new neighbourhoods or schools, digital platforms provide a vital lifeline to existing friendships. Moreover, social media can serve as a powerful tool for self-expression, allowing young people to share their talents — whether through art, music, or writing — with a global audience that would have been unimaginable a generation ago.

However, the darker side of social media cannot be ignored. Studies conducted by public health organisations have found that certain platforms are strongly linked to increased rates of anxiety, depression, and body image issues among young users. The constant stream of carefully curated images creates unrealistic standards of beauty and success that many teenagers feel compelled to measure themselves against. When they inevitably fall short, feelings of inadequacy and low self-worth follow.

Cyberbullying represents another grave concern. Unlike traditional bullying, which is confined to the school environment, online harassment can follow victims into their homes and into the early hours of the morning. The

anonymity that the internet provides can embolden bullies, making their attacks more vicious and harder to trace. Victims often suffer in silence, afraid that reporting the abuse will worsen their situation or that adults will not fully understand the online world.

Furthermore, the addictive nature of social media platforms is not accidental. These applications are engineered by teams of designers and psychologists to maximise user engagement, using techniques such as variable reward schedules — the same mechanism found in gambling — to keep users scrolling for just a little longer. The result is a generation that struggles to focus, to tolerate boredom, and to simply exist without a screen nearby.

The challenge for parents, educators, and policymakers is not to eliminate social media from young people's lives — a task that is both impractical and counterproductive — but to equip them with the critical thinking skills and digital literacy needed to navigate this complex landscape safely and confidently.

1. According to the passage, how much time does the average teenager spend on social media each day?

[1]

2. Identify **TWO** benefits of social media mentioned in the passage.

[2]

(a)

(b)

3. What does the phrase "*vital lifeline*" (paragraph 2) suggest about the role of social media for teenagers who have changed schools?

[2]

4. Explain in your **own words** why the "constant stream of carefully curated images" (paragraph 3) is harmful to young people.

[3]

5. What are "variable reward schedules" (paragraph 5)? Explain how this technique affects social media users.

[3]

6. Find a word in **paragraph 3** that means "*collected and presented with great care and selectivity.*"

[1]

7. Find a word in **paragraph 4** that means "*to give someone the courage or confidence to do something harmful or bold.*"

[1]

8. What is the writer's view on banning social media for young people? Support your answer with **evidence** from the passage.

[3]

9. How does the writer structure the passage to present a balanced argument? Refer to **specific paragraphs** in your answer.

[4]

10. *"Social media companies should be held fully responsible for the mental health problems of young people."*

[10]

Do you agree? Use **evidence from the passage** and your **own ideas** to support your answer. Write approximately 150–200 words.

SECTION B — LANGUAGE USE [25 marks]

Answer **ALL** questions in this section.

Part 1 — Active and Passive Voice [5 marks]

Rewrite each sentence by changing from **active to passive** or **passive to active** as instructed. Do **not** change the tense.

11. *Scientists have conducted extensive studies on the effects of screen time on young people.* [Change to **passive**] [1]

12. *The new app was downloaded by millions of users within its first week of release.* [Change to **active**] [1]

13. *The school is banning mobile phones during all lesson times.* [Change to **passive**] [1]

14. *Cyberbullying has deeply affected a significant number of teenagers.* [Change to **passive**] [1]

15. *New regulations for social media platforms will be introduced by the government.* [Change to **active**] [1]

Part 2 — Reported Speech [5 marks]

Change each sentence into **reported speech**. Begin with the words given.

16. *"I spend at least four hours on my phone every day," said the student.* [1]

The student said _____

17. *"We will take firm action against cyberbullying," the principal promised.* [1]

The principal promised _____

18. *"Have you ever been bullied online?" the researcher asked the teenager.* [1]

The researcher asked the teenager

19. *The teacher warned, "You must not post personal information on social media."* [1]

The teacher warned (the students)

20. *"Social media is fundamentally changing how teenagers think," the psychologist claimed.* [1]

The psychologist claimed _____

Part 3 — Conditionals [5 marks]

Complete each sentence using the correct form of the verb in brackets. The conditional type is shown in *italics*.

21. If teenagers spent less time online, they _____ (have) more time for outdoor activities. *(2nd conditional)* [1]

22. If the school had introduced a phone policy earlier, many problems _____ (could / avoid). *(3rd conditional)* [1]

23. Unless parents _____ (set) clear limits, children will continue to use phones excessively. [1]

24. If I _____ (be) the Minister of Education, I would make digital literacy a compulsory subject. *(2nd conditional)* [1]

25. She would not have developed such anxiety had she _____ (not / compare) herself constantly to others online. *(3rd conditional)* [1]

Part 4 — Connectives [5 marks]

Choose the most appropriate connective from the box to complete each sentence. Each word is used **once only**.

however | consequently | in addition | despite | whereas

26. Social media connects people across the globe; _____, it can also cause deep feelings of isolation. [1]
27. _____ its many benefits, social media has been closely linked to rising rates of mental health problems. [1]
28. Teenagers in urban areas enjoy fast internet access; _____ those in rural regions often struggle with basic connectivity. [1]
29. Many young people ignore the risks of sharing personal data online; _____, they become vulnerable to identity theft. [1]
30. Social media platforms are free to use; _____ to this, companies earn revenue by selling users' data to advertisers. [1]

Part 5 — Tenses [5 marks]

Fill in each blank with the correct form of the verb in brackets.

31. By the time smartphones were invented, millions of people _____ (already / rely) on landlines as their main means of communication. [1]
32. The researchers _____ (publish) their full findings in a peer-reviewed journal next month. [1]
33. She _____ (scroll) through her social media feed for two hours when her mother called her for dinner. [1]
34. Social media _____ (change) significantly since the first platforms appeared in the early 2000s. [1]
35. At the moment, the parliamentary committee _____ (review) the new digital safety guidelines for young people. [1]

SECTION C — WRITING [30 marks]

Choose **ONE** task only. Write between **250 and 350 words**. Plan your answer before you write.

TASK A — Formal Letter

Write a **formal letter** to the Minister of Education arguing that digital literacy should be a compulsory subject in all secondary schools. Include a clear introduction, at least two developed arguments with supporting evidence, an acknowledgement of opposing views, and a persuasive conclusion.

TASK B — Discursive Essay

Write a **discursive essay** with the title: *"Social media does more harm than good."* Present both sides of the argument clearly, with relevant examples and evidence, before reaching a justified conclusion that reflects your own view.

TASK C — Creative Writing

Write a **short story** that begins: *"The notification appeared on Priya's screen at midnight, and everything changed."* Your story should have a clear setting, developed characters, and a satisfying ending.

Task chosen (circle): **A** **B** **C**

Blank lined paper for writing.

SECTION D — VOCABULARY AND WORD STUDY [15 marks]

Part 1 — Phrasal Verbs [5 marks]

Replace the underlined words with the correct phrasal verb from the box. Write the phrasal verb in the space provided. Do **not** change the tense.

log on to | scroll through | cut down on | look up | switch off

36. She spent the evening browsing lazily through dozens of videos without watching any of them fully. [1]
Answer: _____
37. The doctor advised him to reduce the amount of time he spends on screens each day. [1]
Answer: _____
38. Before the online lesson, students must gain access to the school's learning platform. [1]
Answer: _____
39. She couldn't find the definition in her dictionary, so she decided to search for it online. [1]
Answer: _____
40. Experts recommend that teenagers disconnect completely from their devices at least one hour before bed. [1]
Answer: _____

Part 2 — Word Forms [5 marks]

Complete the table by writing the missing word form in each **shaded cell**. One mark per correct answer.

Verb	Noun	Adjective
communicate		communicative
	creativity	creative
engage	engagement	
	influence	influential
connect		connected

[5 marks: 1 mark per shaded cell]

Part 3 — Idioms in Context [5 marks]

Choose the correct meaning (A, B, or C) for each underlined idiom as used in the sentence. Write the letter only.

41. "After her video went viral, Nadia received thousands of messages from people worldwide." [1]

A. became infected with a computer virus B. spread rapidly to a very large audience C. was removed by the platform

Answer: _____

42. "Feeling in the spotlight after being tagged in an embarrassing photo, he deactivated his account." [1]

A. enjoying fame and popularity B. being watched and judged by many people C. standing under a bright stage light

Answer: _____

43. "The young blogger bit off more than she could chew when she agreed to manage five accounts at once." [1]

A. ate too much at a meal B. took on more responsibility than she could handle C. made a very profitable decision

Answer: _____

44. "Ever since the argument, her classmates have been giving her the cold shoulder both online and in class." [1]

A. sharing cold food with her B. deliberately ignoring and excluding her C. offering her support and encouragement

Answer: _____

45. "Despite practising for weeks, he was still all thumbs when editing videos on his phone." [1]

A. very skilled and efficient B. clumsy and lacking coordination C. using only his thumbs to type

Answer: _____

MARK SCHEME — Paper 1 (Technology / Social Media)

For teacher / examiner use. Accept any answer that is clearly correct in meaning, even if worded differently from the model answer. Where own words are required, do not award marks for direct quotation from the passage unless stated. Apply the writing grid for Q10 and Section C.

Q	Acceptable Answer(s)	Mark
1	Over / more than three hours (per day / daily).	1
2	(a) Maintaining / keeping friendships across distances. (b) Self-expression / sharing talents with a global audience. (1 mark each; either order.)	2
3	It suggests that social media is essential / crucial for these teenagers — without it they would feel cut off from their existing friendships. Award 1 mark for "essential/crucial/indispensable" and 1 mark for linking to staying connected after a difficult change.	2
4	The images are not a true picture of reality — they are carefully selected to look perfect. This leads teenagers to compare themselves to an impossible standard, making them feel they are not good-looking, talented, or successful enough. (1 mark: images are selective/unrealistic; 1 mark: causes unfair comparison; 1 mark: emotional consequence of inadequacy/low self-worth.)	3
5	They are a design technique that gives users an unpredictable reward (e.g. an interesting post or a "like") at irregular intervals, similar to a gambling machine. Effect: users keep scrolling in search of the next reward and become unable to stop / addicted. (1 mark: unpredictable/irregular reward; 1 mark: gambling comparison; 1 mark: behavioural effect of compulsive use.)	3
6	curated	1
7	embolden	1
8	The writer is <i>against</i> banning social media — they believe it is "impractical and counterproductive." Instead they argue for teaching digital literacy. Evidence: "The challenge ... is not to eliminate social media ... but to equip them with the critical thinking skills ..." (1 mark: identifies writer's position against banning; 1 mark: correct evidence; 1 mark: explains the alternative proposed.)	3
9	Award up to 4 marks: [1] Opening paragraph introduces the topic and signals both sides (balanced stance from the start). [1] Paragraph 2 presents benefits clearly. [1] Paragraphs 3–5 systematically present harms, each focusing on a different problem. [1] Final paragraph offers a nuanced solution rather than one-sided condemnation, showing balance. Credit specific paragraph references and comments on connectives/discourse markers.	4

10	Extended response grid (10 marks): Content & argument [4]: Addresses the statement directly; uses at least two points from the passage; adds own ideas; takes a clear position. Organisation [3]: Clear intro and conclusion; logical paragraphing; connectives used purposefully. Language [3]: Accurate grammar and spelling; varied vocabulary and sentence structures; appropriate discursive register.	10
Section B — Language Use		
11	Extensive studies on the effects of screen time on young people have been conducted by scientists.	1
12	Millions of users downloaded the new app within its first week of release.	1
13	Mobile phones are being banned by the school during all lesson times.	1
14	A significant number of teenagers have been deeply affected by cyberbullying.	1
15	The government will introduce new regulations for social media platforms.	1
16	The student said (that) he/she spent at least four hours on his/her phone every day.	1
17	The principal promised (that) they would take firm action against cyberbullying.	1
18	The researcher asked the teenager if / whether he/she had ever been bullied online.	1
19	The teacher warned (the students) that they must not / were not to post personal information on social media.	1
20	The psychologist claimed (that) social media was fundamentally changing how teenagers thought.	1
21	would have	1
22	could have been avoided	1
23	set	1
24	were	1
25	not compared	1
26	however	1
27	Despite	1
28	whereas	1
29	consequently	1
30	in addition	1
31	had already been relying / had already relied	1
32	will publish / are going to publish	1
33	had been scrolling	1

34	has changed	1
35	is reviewing / is currently reviewing	1
Section C — Writing (30 marks)		
C	Content & Task Fulfilment [12]: Task fully addressed; correct form (letter / essay / story); sufficient detail and development; relevant examples or narrative detail. Organisation & Structure [9]: Clear introduction and conclusion; logical paragraphing; effective connectives and discourse markers. Language & Style [9]: Accurate grammar, punctuation and spelling; varied sentence structures; appropriate vocabulary and register for the chosen task.	30
Section D — Vocabulary & Word Study		
36	scroll through	1
37	cut down on	1
38	log on to	1
39	look up	1
40	switch off	1
Word forms	Row 1: communication . Row 2: create . Row 3: engaging . Row 4: influence (verb). Row 5: connection .	5
41	B	1
42	B	1
43	B	1
44	B	1
45	B	1